MAHARASHTRA

A SHIV SENA IN THE MIRROR

By Dhaval Kulkarni

In what came as a formal setback for the Uddhav Thackeray-led faction of the Shiv Sena, Maharashtra assembly speaker Rahul Narwekar held that the camp led by Maharashtra chief minister Eknath Shinde was the "real Shiv Sena". However, Narwekar did not disqualify legislators from either of the two rival factions. In June 2022, Shinde, who was a minister in the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA) coalition led by Thackeray, walked out with 39 MLAs, leading to the fall of that government. Shinde took over as CM in an alliance with the BJP. The two Sena groups had filed 24 petitions before the Speaker in 2022, each seeking disqualification of the other. In December 2023, the Supreme Court had asked Narwekar to decide on the petitions by January 10, 2024.

While this stamp of approval for the Shiv Sena led by Shinde is a symbolic loss for the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray), it can even work to their advantage. Leaders of the Thackeray camp say the verdict may arouse sympathy among Marathi speakers in Mumbai and neighbouring areas who form the Sena's core support base, with Thackeray projecting himself as being wronged by Shinde and the BJP. In this reading, as a matter of fact, the setback is too slight. Because Narwekar refrained from disqualifying the 16 Shiv Sena (UBT) MLAs on technical grounds, Thackeray's associates say they may have been denied a chance to garner greater sympathy electorally.

A Shiv Sena (UBT) source says the ruling formalises a usurpation of the party from the Thackerays by Shinde and the BJP. "We will gain sympathy due to this. The final verdict on who the Sena belongs to will be passed in the Lok Sabha polls," he adds. Thackeray loyalists add that since hardcore Sena cadre see the party and the Thackerays as synonymous, Shinde, who has styled himself as the *mukhya neta* (chief leader), will be regarded as a usurper. Working-class Marathi speakers in Mumbai are seen as emotional voters and have traditionally rallied behind the Sena in times when the party was seen as being in jeopardy.

Even so, symbolic ownership is important in the long run. Thackeray has said they would challenge the ruling in the SC. "This decision will not hold in the SC and even in the minds of the people," he said. Shinde, in turns, says Narwekar's verdict sounds a death-knell to Thackeray's "dynastic rule". "In a democracy, the will of the majority is supreme. We have a majority in the state assembly and the Lok Sabha. The ECI has given us the status of the real Shiv Sena...as we have the majority with us. Today's ruling has smashed authoritarianism and dynastic rule," he said.

SHIV SENA (UBT) LEADERS BELIEVE NARWEKAR'S DECISION WILL CREATE SYMPATHY FOR THEM IN THE MUMBAI REGION

The decision is sure to set off some ripples that may be felt in the larger Mumbai metropolitan region, the Sena's traditional stomping ground that also has 12 of the state's 48 LS seats. However, the bigger battle for the Sena (UBT) lies in accommodating the seat-sharing demands of its allies in the MVA—the Congress, NCP and also the Prakash Ambedkar-led Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi. Shinde's men are pinning their LS hopes on a majoritarian consolidation flowing from Ayodhya. It can eventually boil down to a showdown between Hindu pride and Marathi *asmita*. ■



EKNATH SHINDE
Chief Minister, Maharashtra



UDDHAV THACKERAY
Member, Maharashtra Legislative Council, Shiv Sena (UBT) chief



RAHUL NARWEKAR
Speaker, Maharashtra Legislative Assembly